Headache diary · 8 weeks

Name _____ Start date _____

How to use it

1. Fill in one row every day. On a day without headache, write N under Headache? and leave the rest blank: pain-free days count too.
2. Note when a headache started and ended, and the worst pain from 0 (none) to 10 (worst imaginable). If it goes on past midnight, write "cont." under Started on the next day's row.
3. Write every painkiller or headache medicine you take, prescribed or not, with the dose and time, and whether it helped. Include painkillers taken for other pain, such as period pain.
4. After each 4 weeks, fill in the summary on page 6. Bring the diary to your appointment. For longer, print another copy.

UK guidance (NICE CG150) suggests keeping a headache diary for at least 8 weeks: how often, how long and how bad; other symptoms; all medicines; possible triggers; and any link to your period.

Don't wait: call your emergency number

if you have a headache and:

- it came on suddenly and is extremely painful;
- you cannot move, or have weakness in, an arm or leg on one side, or one side of your face;
- you have problems speaking or remembering things, loss of vision, or blurred or double vision;
- you feel drowsy or confused, or have a seizure;
- you have a very high temperature with a stiff neck, or a rash that does not fade under a glass;
- you have recently had a head injury.

See a doctor the same day (in the UK, NHS 111) if an attack lasts more than 72 hours, aura lasts more than 1 hour, or you are pregnant or have just had a baby.

Key

Symptoms	N nausea or vomiting · L light bothers you · S sound bothers you A aura: warning signs such as zigzag lines, flashing lights or pins and needles, usually less than 1 hour
Kind of medicine	T triptan C combination painkiller, such as one with caffeine or codeine P simple painkiller: paracetamol/acetaminophen, aspirin, ibuprofen or another NSAID O other medicine for the attack: opioid, ergot or another (write its name)
Helped?	Y yes · S somewhat · N no
Period	tick days you have your period

Why count medicine days?

Taking medicine for attacks on many days a month can make headaches more frequent. The international classification (ICHD-3) describes medication-overuse headache in people with headache on 15 or more days a month who, for more than 3 months, have taken: triptans, ergots, opioids or combination painkillers on 10 or more days a month; a mix of these kinds, or of these and simple painkillers, on 10 or more days in total; or simple painkillers alone (one or several) on 15 or more days.

These are diagnostic thresholds, not safe limits: the NHS advises taking painkillers on no more than 2 days a week. Talk to your doctor, and don't stop or change medicines on your own.

Weeks 1–2

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period tick	Notes

Weeks 3–4

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period tick	Notes

Weeks 5–6

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period tick	Notes

Weeks 7–8

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period tick	Notes

Summary for your doctor

Count days, not doses: a day with two doses counts once, and a day with T and P counts under both, and once under any medicine for the attack.

	Headache days	Days with N, L, S or A	Days with P	Days with T	Days with C	Days with O	Days with any medicine for the attack	Worst pain
Weeks 1–4								
Weeks 5–8								

Medicines I take to prevent headaches

Questions for my doctor